Usage of Preposition “À”

The preposition **“à”** is most commonly used as **"to, at, or in,"** in French. Apart from that, it has more meanings and usages. When **à** is followed by the definite article ***le* or *les***, the two words contract.

à + le = au (Masculine singular objects)
à + la = à la (Feminine singular objects)
à + les = aux (Plural objects)

The preposition “à” can be used to convey a variety of information.

To Indicate Function

The preposition **“à”** can introduce an infinitive verb or a noun that indicates the function of the preceding noun.

Français	English
J’ai reçu un ensemble de **verres à vin** en cadeau.	I received a set of **wine glasses** as a gift
Ce **sac à main** est très cher.	This **handbag** is very expensive.
Cette **tasse à thé** est fabriquée en Chine.	This **teacup** is made in China.

To Indicate Possession (Être + à + Possessor)

Français	English
Cet argent **est à Michel**.	This **is Michel’s** money.
L’appartement **était à mon frère** avant sa mort.	The apartment **was my brother’s** before his death.
Ce billet **est à moi**, et celui-ci **est à toi**.	This ticket **is mine** and this one **is yours.**
La voiture jaune **n’est pas à vous**.	The yellow car **is not yours**.

Note : There are multiple ways of expressing possession in French. Possessive adjectives, possessive pronouns, preposition **“de”** all can be used to indicate possession in French.

With Passive Infinitives

The passive infinitive construction is used when the infinitive has a passive role, rather than an active one.

Français	English
Il n'y a plus **rien à dire**.	There is **nothing else to say**.
J'ai plein de **choses à faire** aujourd'hui.	I have plenty of **things to do** today.
Elle a de vieux **vêtements à vendre**.	She has some old **clothes to sell**.
Il reste encore deux **chambres à nettoyer**. C'est trop !	There still remain two **rooms to clean**. It's a lot!

Expressions with Adjective + à

Adjectives related to some kind of ability, attitude, or imminent action are followed by **à + an infinitive or noun.**

Expressions	Examples
Être + apte + à + infinitive (To be capable of)	Je suis apte **à gérer** une équipe. I am capable of managing a team.
Être inapte à + infinitive (To be incapable of)	Nous sommes inaptes **à prêter** l'attention. We are incapable of paying attention.
Être lent(e) à (To be slow at)	Elle est lente **à s'habiller.** She is slow at getting dressed.
Être déterminé(e) à (To be determined to)	J'étais déterminé **à monter** l'Everest, mais il y a eu une tempête de neige. I was determined to climb Everest, but there was a snow storm.
Être destiné(e) à (To be destined to)	Kaustubh était destiné **à enseigner** depuis toujours. Kaustubh was always destined to teach.

After an Adjective (To Introduce an Infinitive)

Français	English
Cette chirurgie est **difficile à faire** et prendra cinq heures.	This surgery is **difficult to do** and will take five hours.
Les sodas sont **malsains à boire**.	Sodas are **unhealthy to drink**.

La langue française est **belle à écouter**.	The French language is **beautiful to hear**.
Notre adresse est très **facile à trouver**.	Our address is very **easy to find**.

To Describe a Characteristic

The preposition **à** can also be used to describe a characteristic of someone/something.

Français	English
Prada a lancé une autre paire de **chaussures à talons hauts**. Les filles deviennent folles.	Prada launched another pair of **high-heeled shoes.** The girls are going crazy.
Je porte des **chemises à manches longues** même en été.	I wear **long sleeved shirts** even in summer
Le suspect était un vieux **monsieur aux cheveux longs** et noirs.	The suspect was an old **man with long black hair**.

To Express a Time Range

We use the preposition **à** to express a range, sometimes with **de** and sometimes without.

Français	English
Les roses tiennent dix **à** douze jours.	Roses last ten **to** twelve days
Elle est en congé **du** samedi **au** mardi.	She is on leave **from** Saturday **to** Tuesday.
Le concert de Coldplay se déroulera **de** novembre **à** décembre. Achetons les billets en avance !	The Coldplay concert will take place from November **to** December. Let's buy the tickets in advance!

With Units of Measurement

The preposition **à** can also depict measurement (with respective units).

Français	English
Mon nouveau boulot me paie **à la semaine**.	My new job pays me **by the week**.
Si vous l'achetez **au kilo**, cela coûtera moins cher.	If you buy it **by the kilo**, it will cost less.
Mon chauffeur roule à 110 km **à l'heure** et c'est dangereux.	My driver goes 110 km **per hour** and it is dangerous.

To Join Two Nouns

To indicate function or to join a noun that modifies another noun. Often, the word exists with “à” as it is.

Français	English
J’ai cassé ma nouvelle **tasse à café**, le jour où je l’ai achetée	I broke my new **coffee cup** the day I bought it.
Il y a une **brosse à dents** supplémentaire dans le placard.	There is an extra **toothbrush** in the cupboard.
Avez-vous une **lime à ongles** ?	Do you have a **nail filer**?

Note : **Une tasse à café** (a coffee cup): This is simply a cup that is used for storing coffee (function), **une tasse de café** (a cup of coffee): This means a cup filled with coffee, so it is used as an expression of quantity.

To talk about Ingredients/Contents

Used for specifying food item contents/flavours **that aren’t the key ingredient of the dish.** So, if you took the ingredient away from the dish, there would still be something left. There, we will use **“à”.**

Français	English
Anne adore **la tarte aux pommes**.	Anne loves **apple pie**.
Chaque matin, je mange **une mousse au chocolat**. J’ai mal au ventre, mais qui s’en soucie ?	Each morning, I eat **a chocolate mousse**. I have a stomach ache, but who cares?
Mon copain fait la meilleure **omelette au fromage**.	My boyfriend makes the best **cheese omelette**.

*La soupe de tomates - Tomato soup (essential ingredient, hence the use of preposition de)
*Le jus d'orange – orange juice (essential ingredient, hence the use of preposition de)